

# Discourse Analysis

*Advanced Topics: Methodology, Philosophy, and Research Design*

## 1. What is Discourse Analysis?

Discourse: *Rule-governed practice of linguistic utterances that constitute reality* (not just represent it). A statement given by Paul-Michel Foucault.

Discourse analysis examines how knowledge, power, and social order are produced through language.

It is not a single method but a spectrum of approaches.

Language is not only used as a tool, but shapes reality. There is an utter difference between just stating we have a change in climate or arguing it is a crisis humanity is facing. It frames the human brain in how its percepts a given statement. Despite it can be proven as fact or not.

Discourse analysis focuses on differences in such language practices: How is making a statement? What is their social position? Which rules are hidden underneath, governing what was said and not or what can be spoken out loud or is a tabu.

## 2. Key Traditions

**Discourse analysis according to Foucault** (archaeological/genealogical): *Discourses as historically specific knowledge orders*. What statements are possible?

**Critical Discourse Analysis** (Norman Fairclough, Ruth Wodak): *Language as social practice*. Discourses *reproduce* or *change* power relations.

**Sociology of Knowledge Approach to Discourse** (Reiner Keller): Discourse as *processes of social knowledge construction*.

## 3. Data Collection and Corpus Building

Discourse analysis makes use of written, spoken or visual sources (documents, speeches, interviews, images, videos).

**Corpus:** Systematic collection of texts/documents covering the discourse segment.

**Selection criteria:** (1) time period, (2) actors/speaker positions, (3) media/artifacts, (4) key events.

Large corpora (1000+ documents) require computer-assisted methods (topic modeling, co-occurrence analysis). E.g. using MAXQDA, AntConc, Voyant Tools, Python, or R (see, for comparison, GermaParl and PolmineR and other associated projects at the University of Duisburg-Essen).

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## 4. Analytical Methods

**Sequence analysis:** Step-by-step unfolding of a discourse event.

**Category-based analysis:** Coding by themes, argumentation patterns, metaphors, legitimation strategies.

**Subject position analysis:** What roles are offered by the discourse? (the '*law-abiding* citizen', the '*concerned* mother', the '*expert*', the '*corrupt*' state)

**Framing analysis:** How is a topic framed? (Is migration framed as a 'crisis', or are migrants framed as 'illegal' or as 'criminal' or compared to that as an 'opportunity' or a 'challenge'?) To whom and why?

**Topos analysis** (Analysis of argumentative patterns): What standard arguments appear? (Economic discourse, Security discourse, Humanitarian discourse, Citizenship discourse.)